

PENGZHEN LI (李鹏振)

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EDUCATION

University of Tennessee, Knoxville
Ph.D. in Economics

expected 2027

Shandong University

2018

M.A. in Finance — thesis published in *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* (1,000+ citations)

Tongji University, Shanghai

2015

B.A. in Economics

RESEARCH INTERESTS

International Trade, Environmental and Energy Economics, Applied Econometrics, and Political Economy.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

Four SSCI/SCI-indexed publications; 1,132 total citations, h-index 4 (Google Scholar, August 2026).

“Do green technology innovations contribute to carbon dioxide emission reduction? Empirical evidence from patent data.” K. Du, **P. Li**, and Z. Yan. *Technological Forecasting and Social Change*, 146 (2019), 297–303. **1,000+ citations (Google Scholar)**.

“Spatial optimization of the sustainable aviation fuel supply chains from forest residues via fast pyrolysis/hydrotreatment considering feedstock ash content variability.” **P. Li**, T. E. Yu, N. Labbé, N. Abdoulmoumine, M. Garcia-Perez, K. P. Hoyt, and B. C. English. *Biomass and Bioenergy*, 208 (2026), 108793.

“Assessing the impact of preprocessing and conversion technologies on the sustainable aviation fuel supply from forest residues in the Southeast USA.” **P. Li**, T. E. Yu, C. Trejo-Pech, J. A. Larson, B. C. English, and D. N. Lanning. *Transportation Research Record*, 2678(9) (2024), 639–654.

“Beef price spread relationship with processing capacity utilization.” C. Martinez, **P. Li**, C. N. Boyer, T. E. Yu, and J. G. Maples. *Journal of the Agricultural and Applied Economics Association*, 2(1) (2023), 133–145.

WORKING PAPERS

Trade Restrictiveness Indices with Discriminatory Tariffs with James Lake [**Job Market Paper**] — application: US–China tariff war, 2018–2024. *Presented at the Midwest Economic Theory and International Trade Meetings, Virginia Tech, 2025.*

Abstract: Trade-restrictiveness indices summarize a country’s tariff schedule as a single welfare-equivalent uniform tariff, but the existing indices assume most-favored-nation tariffs. Since 2018 the largest tariff changes—the US–China tariff war, retaliatory tariffs, and proliferating preferential agreements—have been discriminatory by design. We extend the trade-restrictiveness index to partner-specific tariffs while preserving its welfare interpretation and derive a closed-form decomposition into a “level” component (how much a country restricts trade) and a “discrimination” component (how unevenly it does so). Computing the indices from WITS/Comtrade data for 2017–2024, we find that the MFN-only index systematically understates trade distortions when discrimination is high,

and the decomposition separates, for the first time in this framework, the welfare cost of discrimination from the cost of protection.

A Mean-Field Game of Mayoral Endorsements: Identification and Evidence from Brazilian Coalitional Presidentialism with Matt Van Essen and Luiz Lima. *2024 J. Fred and Wilma Holly Award (best second-year paper)*. [\[paper\]](#) [\[slides\]](#)

Abstract:

Price Risk, Irreversible Investment, and the Welfare Benchmark for the Section 45Z Clean Fuel Production Credit with T. Edward Yu. [\[paper\]](#) [\[slides\]](#)

How Should 45Z Pay for Risk? A Welfare-CVaR and Project-Finance Decomposition of the IRA Clean Fuel Production Credit with T. Edward Yu. [\[paper\]](#) [\[slides\]](#)

Estimating Pork Primal Price Relationships Using a Threshold Vector Autoregressive Analysis with Charles Martinez, Christopher N. Boyer, T. Edward Yu, and David Anderson. *SSRN working paper 4121953 (2022)*. [\[paper\]](#)

WORK IN PROGRESS

A Weight-Free Benchmark for Multilateral Tariff Bargaining with Georg Schaur. *Draft, August 2026*. [\[paper\]](#) [\[slides\]](#)

PRESENTATIONS

Midwest Economic Theory and International Trade Meetings , Virginia Tech	Spring 2025
Western Regional Science Association , Annual Meeting, Hawaii	2023
Western Agricultural Economics Association , Annual Meeting, Santa Fe, NM	2022
Southern Agricultural Economics Association , Annual Meeting, New Orleans, LA	2022

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

University of Tennessee – Knoxville, TN 2020 – present
Graduate Research & Teaching Assistant. USDA NIFA and FAA ASCENT projects (2020–2023): mixed-integer supply-chain optimization (GAMS), IMPLAN/DEA siting analysis, and spatial data pipelines (ArcGIS, R, Python) for forest-residue sustainable aviation fuel; two publications and three working papers.

Shandong University – Jinan, China 2016 – 2018
Graduate Research Assistant. Panel-threshold and machine-learning analysis of green innovation and CO₂ emissions (published in *TFSC*, 2019).

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Tennessee

Instructor

ECON 351: Monetary Economics	Spring 2025, Spring 2026
ECON 322: The Global Economy: Trade and Development	Summer 2025
ECON 313: Intermediate Macroeconomics	Summer 2026

Teaching Assistant

Ph.D. courses:

ECON 511: Microeconomic Theory	Fall 2023, Fall 2024, Fall 2025
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ECON 512: Advanced Microeconomics
ECON 581: Mathematical Methods in Economics
Master's courses:
AREC 525: Agribusiness Operations Research Methods

Spring 2024
Summer 2024

Spring 2022, Spring 2023

HONORS AND AWARDS

Charles B. Garrison Award for Excellence in Teaching, University of Tennessee	2026
Graduate Summer Fellowship, University of Tennessee	2025
J. Fred and Wilma Holly Award (best second-year paper), University of Tennessee	2024
J. Fred and Wilma Holly Fellowship, University of Tennessee	2023 – present
Graduate Assistantship, University of Tennessee	2020 – present
Outstanding Rainbow Volunteer, Tongji University (free tutoring for low-income primary-school students, Shanghai)	

SKILLS

Programming Languages: Stata, R, Python, SQL, GAMS, MATLAB, LaTeX, ArcGIS, IMPLAN.

Methods: panel and causal econometrics (FE, IV, DiD, event study, SCM, GMM, panel threshold), time series (TVAR, VECM, mGARCH), mixed-integer and stochastic programming, DEA, cooperative and mean-field games, machine learning.

Credentials: CFA Level II.

Languages: Chinese (native), English (fluent).

REFERENCES

James Lake

Associate Professor of Economics

Department of Economics

University of Tennessee

Email: jlake7@utk.edu

Georg Schaur

Leigh Burch III Economics Professor and Haslam Family Faculty Fellow

Department of Economics

University of Tennessee

Email: gschaur@utk.edu

T. Edward Yu

Professor of Agricultural and Resource Economics

Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics

University of Tennessee

Email: tyu1@tennessee.edu